



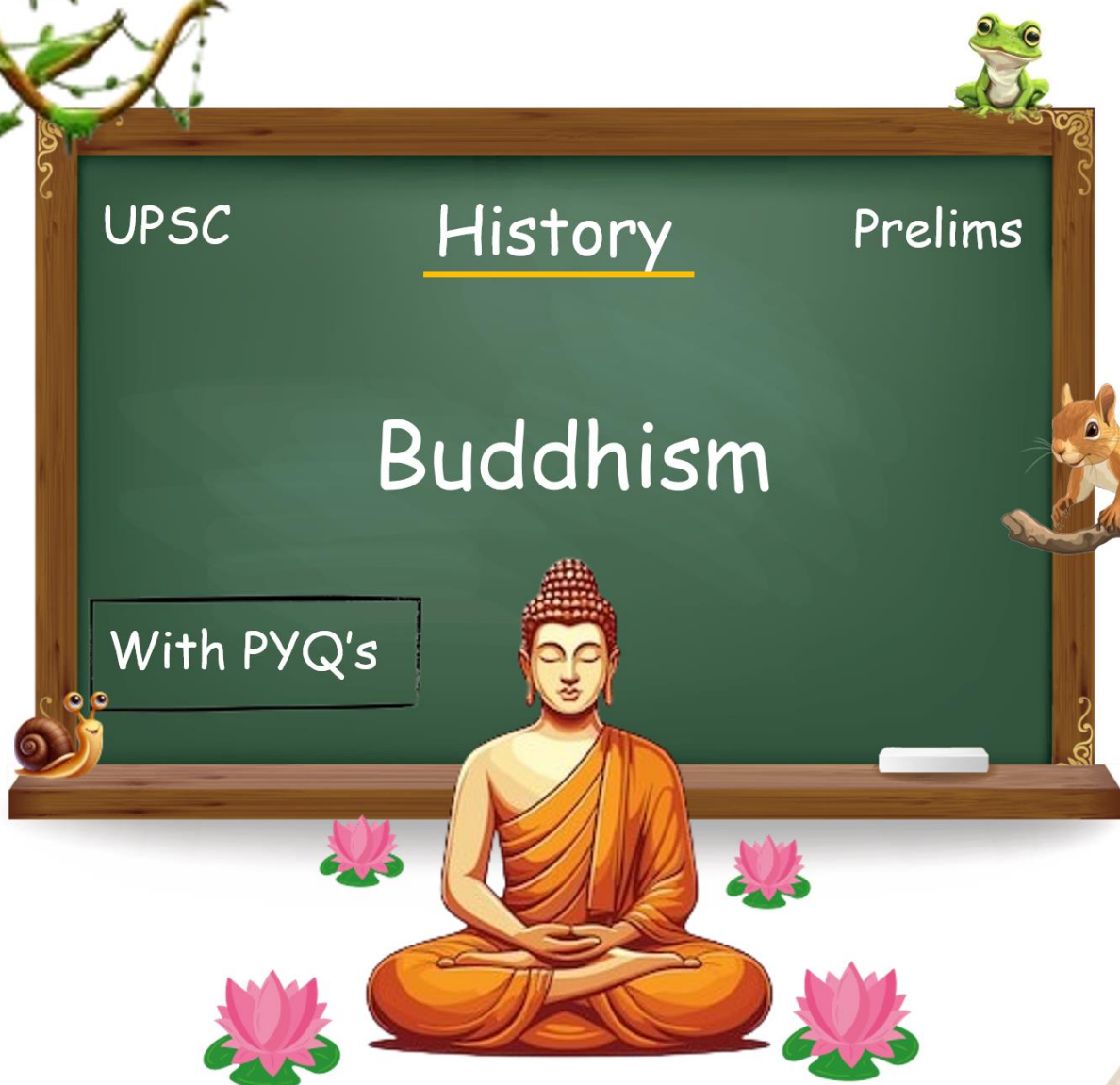
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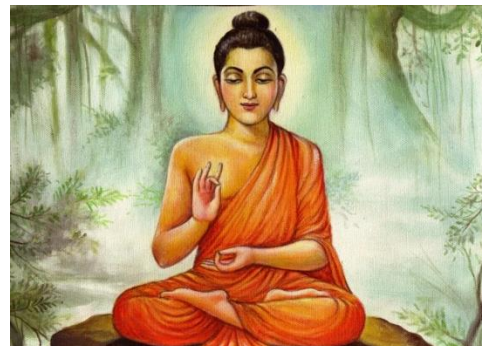


Buddhism

Causes of Origin of Buddhism and Jainism (6th Century BCE)

Background

- The **6th century BCE** marked a phase of **religious and social upheaval** across the world (Confucius in China, Zoroaster in Iran, Parmenides in Greece).
- In India, the **Middle Gangetic plain** witnessed the rise of **62 religious sects**, of which **Buddhism** (founded by Gautama Buddha) and **Jainism** (propounded by Vardhaman Mahavira) emerged as the most influential.
- These religions questioned **ritualism, hierarchy, and materialism**, and emphasised **ahimsa, morality, charity, and simple living**.



Major Causes for Origin

Major Cause	Details	Groups Attracted/Benefited
1. Reaction against Brahmanical Domination	- Varna system placed Brahmanas at the top with privileges (gifts, tax exemption, lenient punishments). - Ritualism and priestly domination resented by Kshatriyas. - Both Buddha & Mahavira were Kshatriyas. - Pali texts even placed Kshatriyas above Brahmanas.	Kshatriyas (rulers, warriors)
2. Rigid Varna System & Social Tensions	- Varna became birth-based , not profession-based. - Vaishyas : Economically strong (trade, agriculture) but socially inferior. - Shudras : Denied Vedic education, treated as low/impure, some untouchables. - Created discontent, demand for egalitarian religions.	Vaishyas, Shudras
3. Agrarian Economy &	- Eastern UP & Bihar: fertile land, high rainfall, forests cleared with	Peasants, farmers



Opposition to Animal Sacrifice	iron tools. - Iron ploughshare agriculture required bullocks . - Vedic animal sacrifices killed cattle, conflicting with agrarian needs. - Buddhism & Jainism opposed sacrifices, promoted ahimsa .	
4. Rise of Urbanisation & Trade (Second Urbanisation)	- Growth of towns (Rajagriha, Vaishali, Varanasi, Patliputra, Ujjaini, etc.). - Expansion of trade, craft production, use of Punch-Marked Coins . - Vaishyas & mercantile groups sought higher social status. - Patronised Buddhism & Jainism since they: rejected caste, preached non-violence, supported trade & money-lending.	Vaishyas, traders, merchants, artisans
5. Popular Appeal of Simple Ethical Teachings	- Economic/social changes → rise of crime, inequality, moral decline. - People desired simplicity, peace, and equality. - Teachings offered: rejection of costly sacrifices, asceticism, equality irrespective of caste/wealth.	General laity (peasants, artisans, common folk)

Life of Gautama Buddha (563 BCE – 483 BCE)

Sources

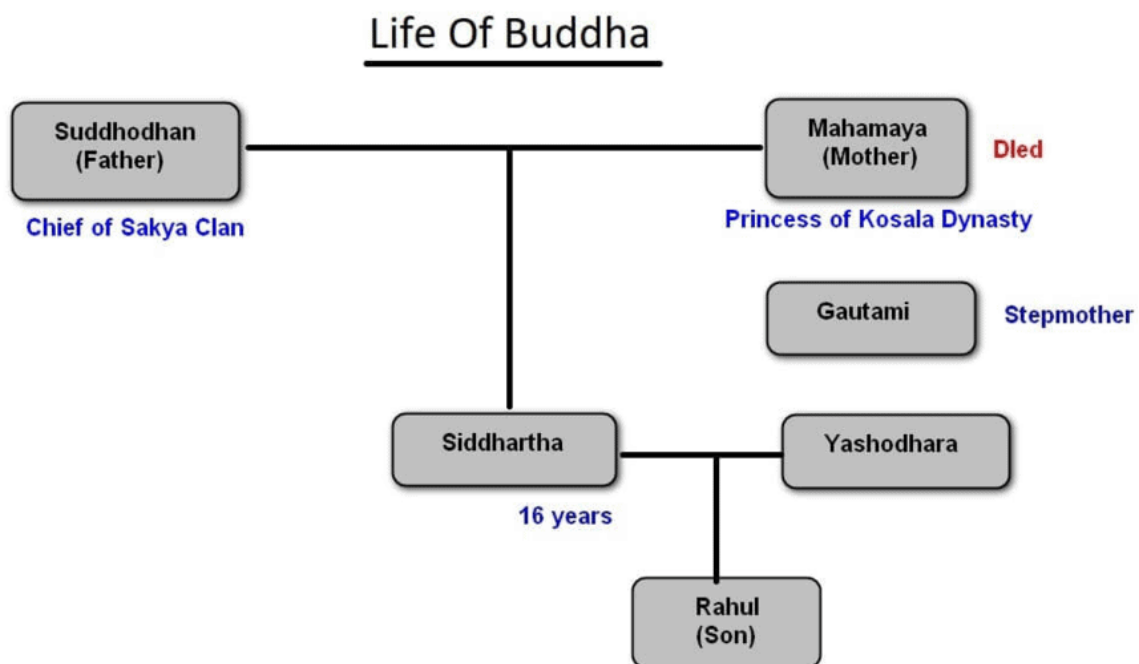
- Early accounts in **Sutta Pitaka** and **Vinaya Pitaka**.
- Later expanded in texts like **Buddhacharita (by Ashvaghosha)**, **Mahavastu**, and **Nidanakatha**.

Early Life

- **Birth:** 563 BCE, on **Vaishakha Poornima** at **Lumbini** (near Kapilavastu, Nepal).
- **Clan:** Shakya Kshatriya clan (hence called **Sakyamuni**).
- **Father:** Suddhodana (chief of the republican Sakya clan, ruling from Kapilavastu in Kosala kingdom).



- **Mother:** Mahamaya (Kosala princess) → died 7 days after his birth.
- **Foster mother:** Mahaprajapati Gautami.
- **Prediction:** Brahmanas identified **32 marks of a Mahapurusha**, predicting he would either be a world conqueror or a great renouncer.
- **Upbringing:** Shielded from sorrows, raised in luxury to prevent renunciation.



Family Life

- **Marriage:** At age 16, married **Yashodhara**.
-
- **Son:** Rahula.
- Despite luxury, he felt discontent at the suffering around him.

Great Renunciation (Mahabhinishkramana)

- **Turning Point:** At age 29, saw the **Four Great Sights**:
 - Old man → ageing
 - Sick man → disease
 - Corpse → death
 - Ascetic → renunciation
- Deeply moved, left palace at night with **charioteer Channa** and horse **Kanthaka** in search of truth.
- Began wandering as a seeker for liberation from human suffering.



Search for Truth

- Initially studied under famous teachers:
 - Alara Kalama** → meditation practices.
 - Uddaka Ramaputta** → higher mental discipline.
 - Rejected both as inadequate for liberation.
- Practised **extreme austerities** for 6 years with five ascetics (Kondanna, Bhaddiya, Vappa, Mahanama, Assaji).
- Severe fasting led to emaciation → realised futility of extreme self-mortification.
- Adopted **Madhyam Marg (Middle Path)** – avoiding both luxury and severe austerity.

Enlightenment (Nirvana)

- Place:** Bodh Gaya (Magadha, Bihar), under a **Peepal tree** (later called Bodhi Tree), on banks of **Niranjana (Phalgu) river**.
- Age:** 35 years.
- Event:**
 - Sujata offered him milk-rice before meditation.
 - Sat on a mat of kusa grass, resolved not to rise until enlightenment.
 - Resisted temptations and assaults of **Mara (Lord of Illusion)**.
 - Attained **Nirvana** after passing through four stages of dhyana (meditative trance).
- Realisation:** Freed from cravings, desires, hatred, and ignorance – became **Buddha (The Enlightened One)**.



First Sermon (Dhammachakra Pravartana)

- Place:** Deer Park at **Sarnath**, near Varanasi.
- Audience:** His five former ascetic companions.
- Event:** “Turning of the Wheel of Dharma” – explained the **Four Noble Truths** and **Eightfold Path**.
- Disciples became **Arhats** (enlightened beings).
- This marked the beginning of the **Buddhist Sangha (monastic order)**.



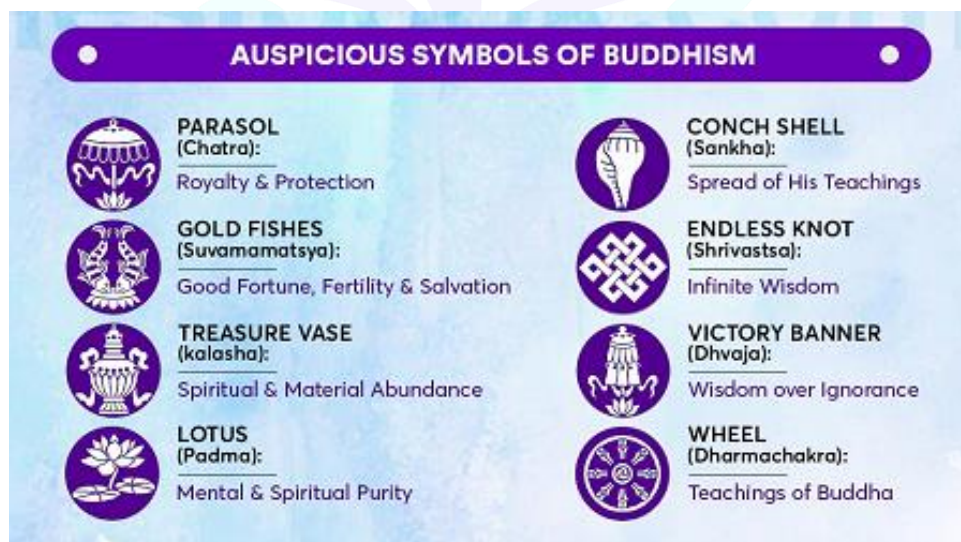
Teaching Career

- Preached for **~45 years** across Magadha, Kosala, and other parts of North India.
- Travelled extensively, teaching in towns, villages, and royal courts.
- **Rested during monsoons** in monasteries (**Viharas**) – often donated by kings and merchants.
- Core Message: Liberation from suffering through **moral conduct, meditation, and wisdom**.

Parinirvana (Death)

- **Age:** 80 years.
- **Year:** 483 BCE.
- **Place:** Kushinagar (Malla republic, present-day Uttar Pradesh).
- **Event:** Passed away under a **Sal tree** → attained **Parinirvana** (final liberation, freedom from rebirth).
- **Last words** (as per tradition): *"All composite things decay; strive diligently for liberation."*

Symbolic Representation of Buddha's Life (Aniconic Phase)



Symbol	Event Represented	Details / Significance
Lotus & Bull	Birth of Buddha	Symbolises purity (Lotus) and strength/auspiciousness (Bull).
Horse (Kanthaka)	Great Renunciation (Mahabhinishkramana)	Represents Buddha leaving palace life in search of truth.



Bodhi Tree	Enlightenment at Bodh Gaya (Mahabodhi)	Under the Bodhi Tree, Siddhartha attained Nirvana (supreme knowledge).
Dharmachakra (Wheel of Dharma)	First Sermon at Sarnath (Dharmachakra Pravartana)	Symbol of turning the Wheel of Dharma (teaching the Four Noble Truths).
Footprints / Stupa	Mahaparinirvana (Death at Kushinagar)	Symbolises Buddha's final salvation (freedom from rebirth).

Doctrines of Buddhism

1. Three Jewels (Triratnas)

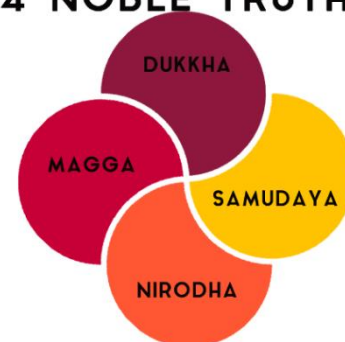
- **Buddha** – the teacher, enlightened one.
- **Dhamma** – teachings of Buddha.
- **Sangha** – order of monks and nuns; custodians of Dhamma.

2. Core Doctrines

(a) Four Noble Truths (Arya Satya)

1. **Dukkha** – Life is full of suffering (birth, disease, old age, death).
2. **Samudaya** – Cause of suffering is **Trishna** (desire/craving).
3. **Nirodha** – Cessation of suffering is possible by conquering desires → leads to Nirvana.
4. **Magga (Marga)** – Path leading to cessation of suffering → **Eightfold Path**.

4 NOBLE TRUTHS



(b) Eightfold Path (Ashtangika Marga)

(Should be practiced simultaneously, not sequentially; forms **Middle Path** avoiding extremes of luxury & asceticism.)

1. Right View/Understanding (Samyak-Drishti)
2. Right Thought/Resolve (Samyak-Sankalpa)
3. Right Speech (Samyak-Vak)
4. Right Action/Conduct (Samyak-Karmanta)
5. Right Livelihood (Samyak-Aajivika)



6. Right Effort (Samyak-Vyayama)
7. Right Mindfulness (Samyak-Smrti)
8. Right Concentration/Meditation (Samyak-Samadhi)

(c) Middle Path (Madhyam Marga)

- Avoids **extreme indulgence** in worldly pleasures and **extreme asceticism**.
- Represents a **balanced, ethical, and meditative life**.

(d) Concept of Nirvana (Nibbana)

- **Literal meaning:** Ni (end) + Vana (craving) → extinction of desire.
- Not annihilation but liberation from cycle of **birth–death (Samsara)**.
- State of **supra-mundane bliss**, free from greed, hatred, ignorance, and ego.
- Can be attained **during one's lifetime** (Sopadisesa Nibbana).
- Final liberation at death of an Arhat → **Parinibbana**.

(e) Doctrine of Dependent Origination (Pratitya-Samutpada)

- Explains cycle of **birth and rebirth (Samsara)**.
- Root cause → **Ignorance (Avidya)** leading to desire and karma.
- Everything is interdependent; nothing has permanent existence.

(f) Three Characteristics of Existence (Tilakkhana)

1. **Dukkha** – suffering.
2. **Anicca (Anitya)** – impermanence of worldly things.
3. **Anatta (Anatman)** – absence of a permanent self or soul.

(g) Concept of Karma in Buddhism

- Karma = **volitional action** (mental volition more important than act).
- Good or bad volitions condition future rebirth.
-
- **Rejects permanent soul (Atman)** but accepts continuity of aggregates (skandhas).



3. Ethical Code

(a) Five Precepts (Panchsila – for laity)

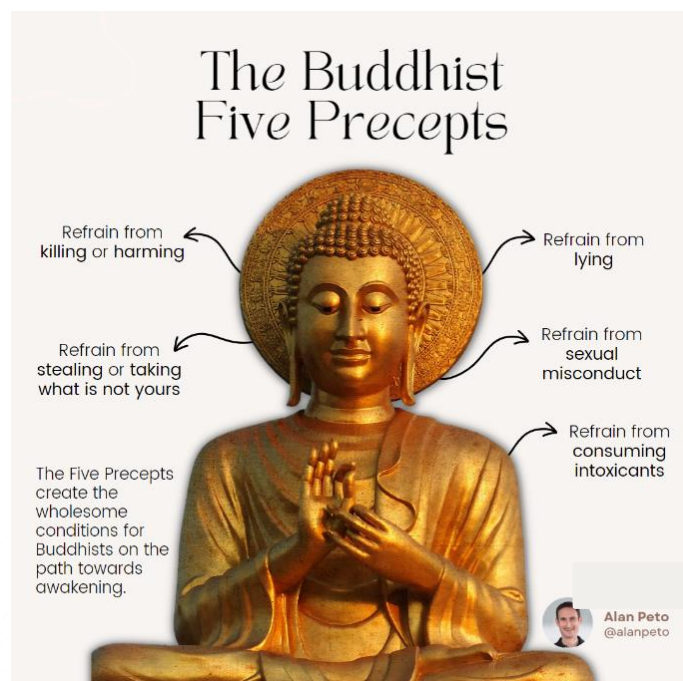
1. Do not kill (non-violence).
2. Do not steal.
3. Avoid sexual misconduct.
4. Do not lie.
5. Do not consume intoxicants.

(b) Additional Precepts (for monks/nuns)

- Not to eat after midday.
- Abstain from dance, music, ornaments, perfumes.
- Avoid luxurious beds, money.

(c) Ten Precepts (Dasa Shila)

- Extended code including celibacy, renunciation of wealth, simplicity, non-corruption.



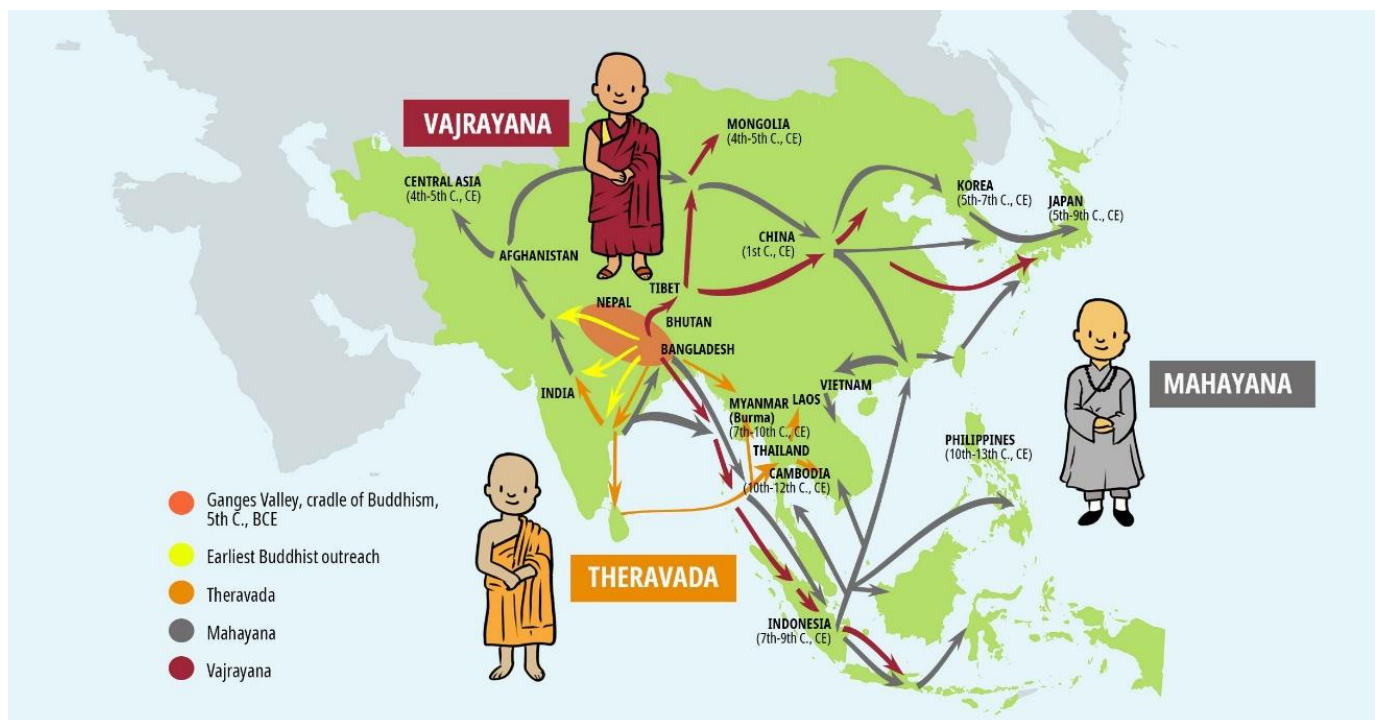
Ten Great Disciples of Buddha

Disciple	Special Attribute	Key Contributions
Śāriputra	Wisdom	Master of Abhidharma , organized Sangha.
Maudgalyāyana (Moggallāna)	Supernatural powers	Known for psychic abilities , linked to ghost festival.
Mahākāśyapa	Asceticism	Strict discipline, led First Council , preserved teachings.
Subhūti	Emptiness (Śūnyatā)	Pioneer of Prajñāpāramitā teachings.
Pūrṇa Maitrāyaniputra	Teaching skill	Renowned preacher, best Dharma teacher .
Kātyāyana (Mahākaccāna)	Doctrine clarification	Simplified complex teachings, Vinaya expert.
Anuruddha	Divine vision	Attained dibba-cakkhu (clairvoyance).



Upāli	Monastic discipline	Master of Vinaya , recited rules at First Council.
Rāhula	Discipline & zeal	Buddha's son, eager learner, model monk.
Ānanda	Memory & devotion	Attendant to Buddha, preserved Sutras , key role at First Council.

Spread of Buddhism



1. During Buddha's Lifetime

- Spread within **Magadha, Kosala, Kaushambi**, and republican states like **Sakyas, Vajjis, Mallas**.
- Attracted **common people, women, and marginalized groups** (due to rejection of caste).

2. Factors for Spread

- **Egalitarian appeal:** no caste/gender discrimination.
- **Language:** Use of **Pali/Prakrit** → accessible to masses (unlike Sanskrit).
- **Simple monastic rules** → easy entry to Sangha.
- **Ethical teachings:** non-violence, compassion, personal responsibility.
- **Support of rulers:** e.g., **Bimbisara, Ajatashatru, Prasenjit**.



- **Missionary zeal** of monks & Sangha.

3. Spread under Mauryas

- **Ashoka's Patronage** (most decisive factor).
 - Sent missions to Sri Lanka (son **Mahendra**, daughter **Sanghamitra**).
 - Supported monasteries, built stupas, inscribed Dhamma edicts.
 - Spread to South-East Asia, West Asia, Central Asia.

4. Post-Mauryan Spread

- **Hinayana (Theravada)**:
 - Patronised by rulers of Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Thailand.
 - Spread via maritime trade routes.
- **Mahayana** (under Kushanas, esp. **Kanishka**):
 - 4th Buddhist Council (Kashmir).
 - Spread via **Silk Route** → Central Asia, China.
 - Adopted ideas of Bodhisattvas & worship of Buddha images.
- **Vajrayana (8th c. CE)**:
 - Developed in India; spread to **Tibet & Nepal**.
 - Absorbed local Bon traditions.
 - Role of **Padmasambhava, Atisha Dipankara**.

5. Spread Beyond India

- **Sri Lanka** → stronghold of Theravada.
- **South-East Asia** → Myanmar, Thailand, Cambodia, Laos.
- **China** → via Silk Route; integrated with Daoism & Confucianism.
- **Korea & Japan** → Mahayana; Zen and Pure Land sects emerged.
- **Tibet** → Vajrayana; Dalai Lama seen as Bodhisattva Avalokiteshvara.

6. Decline in India

- Revival of Brahmanism (Guptas onwards).
- Division into sects (Hinayana, Mahayana, Vajrayana).
- Sanskritisation of Buddhism reduced mass appeal.
- Decline of trade & urban centres (which supported monasteries).
- Muslim invasions (12th c.) destroyed major monasteries like **Nalanda, Vikramashila**.



Reasons for Spread and Popularity of Buddhism

1. Social Factors

- **Egalitarian Approach** – Buddhism rejected the **Varna system**, attracted lower castes and marginalized groups.
- **Inclusivity** – Open to all castes, communities, and women (via entry into the **Sangha**).
- **Non-Vedic People** – Provided religious identity to groups excluded from Brahmanical orthodoxy (e.g., Magadhans).

2. Religious & Philosophical Appeal

- **Simple Doctrine** – Focus on **Four Noble Truths** and **Eightfold Path**; rational, ethical, and free from ritualism.
- **Buddha's Personality** – His calm, rational, and persuasive demeanor inspired confidence.
- **Freedom from Rituals** – No costly sacrifices or priestly domination.

3. Linguistic Advantage

- **Use of Pali/Prakrit** – Buddha's teachings were in **vernacular**, accessible to common masses, unlike Sanskrit texts of Brahmanism.

4. Political Support

- Patronage from rulers such as:
 - **Bimbisara & Ajatashatru (Magadha), Prasenajit (Kosala)**, various **Gana-sanghas**.
 - **Emperor Ashoka** – State support, missionary work (Sri Lanka, Central Asia, West Asia), building stupas & viharas.

5. Economic & Material Context

- **Response to Urbanization** – Buddhism addressed new issues of 6th century BCE (wealth accumulation, social disparities).
- **Ethical Economic Values** – Condemned violence, greed, and luxury; promoted simplicity and compassion.



Schools of Buddhism (Later Broad Divisions)

School	Meaning	Time/Origin	Core Features	Language	Spread / Patrons
Hinayana / Theravada	"Lesser Vehicle" / "Doctrine of Elders"	Oldest form; developed after 2nd Buddhist Council (383 BCE)	- Strict adherence to Buddha's original teachings. - Arhat ideal (personal salvation). - Non-theistic: Buddha seen as a great teacher, not divine. - Rejection of idol worship, focus on symbols (Wheel, Tree, Stupa).	Pali	Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Thailand, Cambodia, Laos. Patronised by Ashoka (3rd Council) & Sri Lankan kings.
Mahayana	"Greater Vehicle"	Emerged ~1st century CE (finalised at 4th Council under Kanishka, 72 CE)	- Bodhisattva ideal (universal salvation). - Buddha = divine saviour. - Idol worship and elaborate rituals. - Emphasis on faith & compassion over strict monastic discipline.	Sanskrit	China, Korea, Japan, Vietnam, Nepal. Supported by Kanishka, Harsha.
Vajrayana	"Thunder bolt Vehicle" / Tantric Buddhism	Origin ~7th century CE, Bengal–Bihar region; grew in Tibet	- Integration of Tantric practices (mantras, mudras, mandalas). - Guru/ Lama central authority. - Female divinities like	Sanskrit + Tibetan	Tibet, Nepal, Bhutan, Mongolia. Dalai Lama tradition.



			Tara. - Rituals for faster salvation.		
Navayana	"New Vehicle"	20th c. (Dr. B.R. Ambedkar, 1956)	- Rejects doctrines of karma, rebirth, Nirvana, monkhood. - Reinterprets Buddhism as social revolution and equality. - Strong anti-caste emphasis.	Modern Indian languages	India (Dalit movement).

Early Buddhist Sects (Post-Second Council Splits)

After the **Second Council (383 BCE, Vaishali)** → split into:

1. Sthaviravada (Theravada)

- Conservative group of Elders.
- Strict adherence to Vinaya rules.
- **Beliefs:**
 - Buddha as **Devatideva** (God of Gods) but still human.
 - Emphasis on individual liberation (Arhat ideal).
 - Three core doctrines: **Anatta (no soul), Anitya (impermanence), Dukkha (suffering)**.
- Spread → Sri Lanka & SE Asia.

2. Mahasanghika

- Liberal group (majority).
- Relaxed monastic discipline.
- **Beliefs:**
 - Buddha is **superhuman / transcendental being**.
 - Greater emphasis on Bodhisattvas than Arhats.
 - Flexible rules to attract lay followers.
- Later laid groundwork for **Mahayana**.



3. Sarvastivada

- "All exists" (past, present, future realities are real).
- Doctrines compiled in **Mahavibhasa** (encyclopaedia of Sarvastivada philosophy).
- Strong in Kashmir, Gandhara, Central Asia.
- Patronised by **Kanishka**.

4. Sammitiya

- Emerged from Sthaviravada.
- Rejected doctrine of **Anatta (soullessness)** → believed in existence of an individual personality.
- Popular sect at one point, but later declined.

5. Sautrantika

- Offshoot of Sarvastivada.
- Name = "Followers of Sutras" (relied only on Sutra Pitaka).
- Critical of Abhidhamma and rejected naive realism.
- Emphasised perception as valid source of knowledge.

Major Buddhist Councils

Council	Date	Place	Patron	Chairman	Outcome
First	483 BCE	Rajgriha (Saptaparni cave)	Ajatshatru	Mahakassapa	Compilation of <i>Vinaya Pitaka</i> (Upali) & <i>Sutta Pitaka</i> (Ananda).
Second	383 BCE	Vaishali	Kalasoka	Sabakami	Schism → Sthaviravada vs Mahasanghika .
Third	250 BCE	Pataliputra	Ashoka	Moggaliputta Tissa	Expulsion of heretics; compilation of <i>Kathavatthu</i> ; missionary spread



					(Mahinda to Sri Lanka).
Fourth (India)	72 CE, Kashmir (Kundalvana)	Kanishka	Vasumitra (Chair), Asvaghosh a (Vice-chair)	Division into Hinayana & Mahayana ; doctrines codified in Sanskrit.	
Fourth (Sri Lanka)	25 BCE	Alu Vihara, SL	King Vattagamin i (Valgamba)	–	Pali Canon written on palm leaves after famine.

Doctrinal Concepts

- **Pratyeka-Buddhas** → Solitary Buddhas, attain enlightenment independently, don't teach.
- **Bodhisattvas** → Enlightened beings who postpone Nirvana to help others (Avalokiteshvara, Manjushri, Vajrapani, Maitreya, Kshitigarbha).
- **Dhyani-Buddhas (Five Wisdom Buddhas)** → Vairochana, Akshobhya, Ratnasambhava, Amitabha, Amoghasiddhi.

Difference: Hinayana vs Mahayana

Basis	Hinayana (Theravada)	Mahayana
Ideal	Arhat (personal salvation)	Bodhisattva (universal salvation)
Language	Pali	Sanskrit
Buddha	Human teacher	Divine being
Worship	Symbols (Stupa, Tree, Wheel)	Idol worship, Bodhisattvas
Salvation	Through self-effort, meditation, discipline	Through faith, grace, compassion
Spread	Sri Lanka, SE Asia	China, Korea, Japan, Tibet



Concept of Bodhisattvas

1. Definition

- In **Mahayana & Vajrayana Buddhism** – Bodhisattva is a being who delays own Nirvana to help all sentient beings attain salvation.
- Embodies **compassion (karuna)** and **wisdom (prajna)**.
- Frequently depicted in art, sculpture, and Buddhist literature.

2. Key Bodhisattvas (UPSC-Relevant)

Bodhisattva	Key Features & Significance
Avalokitesvara (Padmapani, Lokeshvara)	Bodhisattva of Compassion; symbolised by lotus flower ; murals in Ajanta Caves ; Dalai Lama regarded as incarnation.
Manjusri	Bodhisattva of Wisdom ; holds sword (cuts ignorance) and book (wisdom); protector deity around Buddha.
Vajrapani	Embodies power of Buddha; depicted with thunderbolt ; guardian against evil, akin to Indra.
Maitreya	Future Buddha ; will descend to earth to re-establish Dharma; “Laughing Buddha” often linked to him.
Ksitigarbha	Bodhisattva of hell realms ; vows not to attain Buddhahood until all beings in hell are liberated.
Samantabhadra	Symbolises practice & meditation ; part of Shakyamuni Triad with Buddha and Manjusri.
Akasagarbha	Symbolises infinite space , boundless compassion & wisdom.
Tara	Female Bodhisattva in Vajrayana; saviour, protector, helps overcome obstacles.
Vasudhara	Associated with wealth & prosperity ; popular in Nepal.
Skanda	Protector of monasteries (Viharas) and Buddha’s teachings.
Sitatapatra	Protector deity; shields from supernatural dangers.



Buddhist Literature

Classification of Buddhist Literature

- **Canonical (Authoritative) Texts** → Directly linked to Buddha, considered scriptures.
- **Non-Canonical / Semi-Canonical Texts** → Commentaries, chronicles, biographies, treatises, written later in Pali, Sanskrit, Prakrit, Tibetan, Chinese, etc.

Canonical Literature – Tripitaka (Three Baskets)

- **Compiled orally** after Buddha's death; written down ~1st century BCE (Sri Lanka).
- **Language:** Pali (Theravada) / Sanskrit (Mahayana).
- **Divisions:**

(a) Vinaya Pitaka (Discipline Basket)

- Rules for monks & nuns; organisation of **Sangha**.
- **Content:**
 - **Patimokkha** → list of transgressions & atonements.
 - **Khandhaka** → *Mahavagga* (awakening of Buddha, disciples), *Cullavagga* (councils, nuns).
 - **Parivara** → summary & analysis of monastic rules.

(b) Sutta Pitaka (Basket of Discourses)

- Buddha's sermons = *Buddhavaacana* ("Word of the Buddha").
- Accepted by all Buddhist schools.
- **Divided into 5 Nikayas:**
 1. **Digha Nikaya** → long discourses.
 2. **Majjhima Nikaya** → middle-length discourses.
 3. **Samyutta Nikaya** → connected discourses.
 4. **Anguttara Nikaya** → numerical discourses.
 5. **Khuddaka Nikaya** → minor collection (includes *Jatakas*, *Dhammapada*, *Theragatha*, *Therigatha*, *Udana*, *Buddhavamsa*, etc.).



(c) Abhidhamma Pitaka (Higher Teachings)

- Philosophical & psychological analysis of teachings.
- **Main Texts:**
 - *Dhammasangani* (classification of dhammas).
 - *Vibhanga* (18 chapters, doctrinal analysis).
 - *Dhatukatha* (discussion of elements).
 - *Puggalapannatti* (classification of persons).
 - *Kathavatthu* (philosophical debates).
 - *Yamaka* (paired questions).
 - *Patthana* (conditional relations).

Semi-Canonical & Non-Canonical Works

(a) Commentarial & Guidance Texts

- **Milindapanho** (Questions of Milinda) → dialogue between Indo-Greek King Menander (Milinda) & monk Nagasena.
- **Nettipakarana / Petakopadesa** → expositions on Buddha's teachings.
- **Visuddhimagga (Path to Purification)** → by *Buddhaghosa*; major Theravada commentary.

(b) Biographical & Hagiographical Works

- **Nidanakatha** → earliest connected life story of Buddha.
- **Mahavastu** (mixed Sanskrit–Prakrit) → hagiography of Buddha (Lokottaravada school).
- **Lalitavistara** (Sanskrit) → detailed life story of Buddha.
- **Buddhacharita** (epic by *Ashvaghosha*) → life of Buddha.
- **Saundarananda** (*Ashvaghosha*) → story of Buddha's half-brother Nanda.

(c) Chronicles (Sri Lankan Pali Literature)

- **Dipavamsa** ("Island Chronicle") → early account of Buddhism in Sri Lanka.
- **Mahavamsa** ("Great Chronicle", by *Mahanama*) → Buddha's life, councils, Ashoka, arrival in Sri Lanka.
- **Culavamsa** → continuation of Mahavamsa.

(d) Avadana Literature (Noble Deeds Stories)

- **Divyavadana** (Sanskrit anthology, includes *Ashokavadana*).



- **Avadanashataka** → 100 stories of noble deeds.

(e) Other Important Works

- **Dhammapada** → ethical verses (Khuddaka Nikaya).
- **Theragatha & Therigatha** → poems by monks & nuns.
- **Udana** → stories (includes "Blind men & Elephant").
- **Udanavarga** → Sanskrit parallel of *Dhammapada*.

Sanskrit Buddhist Literature (Mahayana & Later Works)

- **Ashvaghosha** → *Buddhacharita*, *Saundarananda*, *Sariputra Prakarana*, *Vajrasuchi* (on caste system).
- **Nagarjuna** (2nd c. CE, Madhyamaka) → *Madhyamika Karika*, *Prajnaparamita Karika*.
- **Vasumitra** → *Mahavibhasa Sastra* (encyclopaedia, Sarvastivada).
- **Dignaga** (480–540 CE) → founder of Buddhist logic; *Pramanasamuccaya*.
- **Dharmakirti** (7th c.) → advanced Buddhist epistemology; *Pramanavarttika*.
- **Chandrakirti** (7th c., Madhyamaka) → *Madhyamakavatara*, *Prasannapada*.
- **Atisa Dipankara** (11th c.) → spread of Mahayana & Vajrayana to Tibet.

Important Buddhist Writers

Thinker	Period/Patron	Contribution
Asvaghosha	1st–2nd c. CE, contemporary of Kanishka	<i>Buddhacharita</i> (life of Buddha, Sanskrit epic), poet-dramatist, spread Mahayana.
Nagarjuna	2nd c. CE, Satavahana period	Founder of <i>Madhyamaka</i> / <i>Shunyavada</i> (Middle Path realism–nihilism balance).
Asanga	4th c. CE, Punjab	Founded <i>Yogachara/Vijnanavada</i> school (Idealism).
Vasubandhu	4th–5th c. CE, brother of Asanga	<i>Abhidharmakosa</i> → encyclopaedia of Buddhism.
Buddhaghosa	5th c. CE, Sri Lanka	Pali scholar, <i>Visuddhimagga</i> ("Path of Purification"), codified Theravada.
Dinnaga	5th c. CE	Founder of <i>Buddhist logic (Hetuvidya)</i> .
Dharmakirti	7th c. CE	Refined logic, epistemology; <i>Pramanavarttika</i> .



Decline of Buddhism in India (6th BCE – 12th CE)

1. Internal Causes

- **Ritualism & Corruption** – Monasteries became rich, monks idle & corrupt → loss of moral authority.
- **Alienation from Masses** – Shift from **Pali to Sanskrit** cut off common people.
- **Fragmentation into Sects** – Hinayana, Mahayana, Vajrayana etc. diluted simplicity.
- **Decline of Discipline** – Monasteries turned into centres of luxury, lost missionary zeal.

2. External Causes

- **Loss of Royal Patronage** – Post-Maurya/Kushana, rulers favoured Brahmanism.
- **Persecution** – Pushyamitra Shunga, Mihirakula, Shashanka attacked Buddhist sites.
- **Hindu Revival & Bhakti** – Absorbed Buddhist rituals; masses shifted to temple-Bhakti traditions.
- **Fall of Universities** – Nalanda, Vikramashila declined, later destroyed by Turks.
- **Foreign Invasions** – Huna & Turkish raids (Bakhtiyar Khilji, 12th CE) killed monks, destroyed monasteries.

3. Broader Factors

- Buddha absorbed as **Vishnu's avatar** in Hinduism.
- **Bhakti movement** offered direct salvation.
- Weak political support hastened decline.

By 12th century CE, Buddhism disappeared from India but thrived abroad (Sri Lanka, Tibet, SE Asia).

Significance & Impact of Buddhism

I. Social

- Rejected caste; admitted women & Shudras → dignity to oppressed.
- Stressed ethical living: right livelihood, non-violence, compassion.
- Criticised materialism & hereditary caste but respected political order.



II. Religious & Philosophical

- Alternative to ritualistic Brahmanism → simple, rational path.
- Focus on Nirvana, Sangha discipline, Four Noble Truths, Eightfold Path.
- Doctrinal impact: Ahimsa, Bodhisattva ideal of compassion.

III. Economic

- Condemned exploitation; urged fair wages & ethical trade.
- Monasteries as centres of donations, economy & trade networks.

IV. Cultural

- Art: Stupa, Chaitya, Vihara; Ajanta–Ellora caves.
- Schools: Gandhara (realistic), Mathura (indigenous), Amaravati (narrative).
- Literature in Pali/Prakrit: Tripitakas, Jatakas.

V. Educational

- Universities: Nalanda, Vikramshila, Taxila → taught philosophy, medicine, astronomy, arts.
- Monks spread knowledge abroad; pioneered residential university model.

VI. Political

- Patronage: Ashoka, Kanishka, Harsha.
- Ashoka's Dhamma → tolerance & compassion.
- Served as unifying cultural & diplomatic force.

VII. Global

- Spread to Sri Lanka, Central & East Asia → fusion with local traditions.
- Modern relevance: peace, inclusion, non-violence (inspired Gandhi, MLK, Ambedkar).

Conclusion

- By the 12th century CE, Buddhism had largely disappeared from India.
- The decline was **not sudden**, but gradual—shaped by **internal decay (corruption, sectarianism, Sanskritisation)** and **external challenges (persecution, revival of Hinduism, foreign invasions)**.



- However, Buddhism **flourished abroad**—in Sri Lanka, Tibet, China, Japan, and Southeast Asia—through the missionary zeal of monks and the support of foreign.

BUDDHISM PYQ's :

(without answers for Practice)

1. At which place Gautama Buddha delivered his first sermon?

UPSC 1980 & SSC 2008 & 2018

- (a) Sarnath
- (b) Lumbini
- (c) Bodh Gaya
- (d) Vaishali

2. Which of the following was the most important characteristic of Kanishka's rule?

UPSC 1980

- (a) Expansion of Buddhism outside India
- (b) Reemergence of Jainism
- (c) Fourth Buddhist Council at Srinagar
- (d) Gandhara School of Art

3. In the Mahayana Buddhism, the Bodhisatva Avalokitesvara was also known as:

- (a) Vajrapani
- (b) Manjusri
- (c) Padmapani
- (d) Maitreya

UPSC 1997

4. Milindapanho is in the form of a dialogue between the king Menander and Buddhist monk

- (a) Nagasena
- (b) Nagarjuna
- (c) Nagabhatta
- (d) Kumarilabhatta

UPSC 1997

5. Many of the Greeks, Kushanas and Shakas embraced Buddhism rather than Hinduism because

UPSC 1998

- (a) Buddhism was in the ascendant at that time
- (b) they had renounced the policy of war and violence
- (c) caste-ridden Hinduism did not attract them
- (d) Buddhism provided easier access to Indian society

6. Which of the following pairs are correctly matched?

UPSC 1998

1. Lothal : Ancient dockyard
2. Sarnath : First Sermon of Buddha
3. Rajgir : Lion capital of Ashoka
4. Nalanda : Great seat of Buddhist learning

Codes:

- (a) 1, 2, 3 and 4
- (b) 3 and 4
- (c) 1, 2 and 4
- (d) 1 and 2



7. According to Buddhism the cause of all sorrows is

- (A) Maya **WBPS 2016**
(B) Kama
(C) Trishna
(D) Krodh

8. Who among the following presided over the Buddhist Council held during the reign of Kanishka at Kashmir?

- (a) Parsva **UPSC 2001**
(b) Nagarjuna
(c) Sudraka
(d) Vasumitra

9. In ancient Indian Buddhist monasteries, a ceremony called Pavarana used to be held. It was the

UPSC 2002

- (A) occasion to elect the Sangiparinayaka and two speakers one on Dhamma and the other on Vinaya
(B) confession by monks of their offences committed during their stay in the monasteries during the rainy season
(C) ceremony of initiation of new person into the Buddhist Sangha in which the head is shaved and when yellow robes are offered
(D) gathering of Buddhist monks on the next day to the full-moon day of Ashadha when they take up a fixed abode for the next four months of the rainy Season

10. Consider the following statements: UPSC 2004

1. The Chinese pilgrim Fa-Hien attended the fourth Great Buddhist Council held by Kanishka.
 2. The Chinese pilgrim Huen-Tsang met Harsha and found him to be antagonistic to Buddhism.
- (a) 1 only
(b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2
(d) Neither 1 nor 2

11. Why did Buddhism start declining in India in the early medieval times? UPSC 2010

1. Buddha was by that time considered as one of the incarnations of Vishnu and thus became a part of Vaishnavism.
 2. Invading tribes from Central Asia till the time of last Gupta king adopted Hinduism and persecuted Buddhists.
 3. Kings of Gupta dynasty were strongly opposed to Buddhism.
- (a) 1 only
(b) 1 and 3 only
(c) 2 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3



12. Lord Buddha's image is sometimes shown with the hand gesture called 'Bhumisparsha Mudra'. It symbolizes **UPSC 2012**

- (a) Buddha's calling of the Earth to watch over Mara and to prevent Mara from disturbing his meditation
- (b) Buddha's calling of the Earth to witness his purity and chastity despite the temptations of Mara
- (c) Buddha's reminder to his followers that they all arise from the Earth and finally dissolve into the Earth, and thus this life is transitory
- (d) Both the statements (a) and (b) are correct in this context

13. Which one of the following describes best the concept of Nirvana in Buddhism? **UPSC 2013**

- (a) The extinction of the flame of desire
- (b) The complete annihilation of self
- (c) A state of bliss and rest
- (d) A mental stage beyond all comprehension.

14. The 'Four Noble Truths' propounded by Buddha are centred upon **GPSC 2017**

- 1. Suffering and its extinction
- 2. Right Action
- 3. Ultimate reality
- 4. Salvation

15. With reference to Buddhist history, tradition & culture in India, consider the following pairs:

- 1. Tabo monastery and temple complex : Spiti Valley
- 2. Lhotsava Lhakhang temple, Nako : Zaskar Valley
- 3. Alehi temple complex : Ladakh

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only **UPSC 2014**
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

16. Which of the following Kingdoms were associated with the life of the Buddha?

- 1. Avanti **UPSC 2014**
- 2. Gandhara
- 3. Kosala
- 4. Magadha
- (a) 1, 2 and 3
- (b) 2 and 4
- (c) 3 and 4 only
- (d) 1, 3 and 4

17. With reference to the religious history of India, consider the following statements:

- 1. Sautrantika and Sanmitiya were the sects of Jainism.
- 2. Sarvastivadin held that the constituents of phenomena were not wholly momentary, but existed forever in a latent form.
- (a) 1 only **UPSC 2017**
- (b) 2 only



- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) Neither 1 nor 2

18. With reference to Indian history, who among the following is a future Buddha, yet to come to save the world?

- (a) Avalokiteshvara **UPSC 2018**
- (b) Lokeshvara
- (c) Maitreya
- (d) Padmapani

19. Consider the following:

1. Deification of the Buddha
2. Treading the Path of Bodhisattvas
3. Image worship and rituals

Which of the above is/are the feature/features of Mahayana Buddhism?

- (a) 1 only **UPSC 2019**
- (b) 1 and 2 only
- (c) 2 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

20. With reference to the religious history of India, consider the following statements: **UPSC 2020**

1. Sthaviravadins belong to Mahayana Buddhism.
 2. Lokottaravadin sect was an offshoot of Mahasanghika sect of Buddhism.
 3. The deification of Buddha by Mahasanghikas fostered Mahayana Buddhism.
- (a) 1 and 2 only
 - (b) 2 and 3 only

- (c) 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

21. With reference to Indian history, consider the following pairs: **UPSC 2022**

1. Aryadēva - Jaina scholar
2. Dignaga - Buddhist scholar
3. Nathamuni - Vaishnava scholar

How many pairs given above are correctly matched?

- (a) None of the pairs
- (b) Only one pair
- (c) Only two pairs
- (d) All three pairs

22. With reference to ancient India, consider the following statements: **UPSC CSE 2023**

1. The concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin.
2. Stupa was generally a repository of relics.
3. Stupa was a votive and commemorative structure in Buddhist tradition.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

23. Sanghabhuti, an Indian Buddhist monk, who travelled to China at the end of the fourth century AD, was the author of a



commentary on : UPSC CSE 2024

- (a) Prajnaparamita Sutra
- (b) Visuddhimanga
- (c) Sarvastivada Vinaya
- (d) Lolitavistara

24. With reference to ancient India, Gautama Buddha was generally known by which of the following epithets?

- 1. Nayaputta
- 2. Shakyamuni
- 3. Tathagata

UPSC CSE

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1, 2 and 3
- (d) None of the above are epithets of Gautama Buddha

25. Fa-hien (Faxian), the Chinese pilgrim, travelled to India during the reign of

- (a) Samudragupta
- (b) Chandragupta II
- (c) Kumaragupta I
- (d) Skandagupta

UPSC CSE 2025

26. The important contribution of Jainism to Indian Philosophy is the doctrine of

- 1. Rebirth
- 2. Karma
- 3. Existence of Individual souls
- 4. Syadvada

GPSC 2017

27. Which one of the following statements about Buddhist Stupas in India is not correct? CDS 1 2018

- (a) Ashoka played an important role in popularizing the Stupa cult.
- (b) They were repositories of relics of Buddha and other monks.
- (c) They were located in rural areas.
- (d) They were located close to trade routes.

28. In which predominantly Buddhist nation of Asia did Pope Francis in November 2017 preach a message of forgiveness to a huge crowd?

- (a) Bhutan
- (b) Myanmar
- (c) Thailand
- (d) Mongolia

SSC 2018

29. The Buddha delivered his first sermon, known as 'Turning of the wheel of law' at

- (a) Sanchi
- (b) Sarnath
- (c) Sravasti
- (d) Bodh Gaya

CDS 2008

30. In Buddhism, what does Patimokkha stand for? CDS 2008

- (a) A description of Mahayana Buddhism
- (b) A description of Hinayana Buddhism
- (c) The rules of the Sangha
- (d) The questions of king Menander

31. The earliest Buddhist literature which deal with the stories of the various birth of Buddha are

- (a) Vinaya pitakas

CDS 2011



- (b) Sutta pitakas
- (c) Abhidamma pitakas
- (d) Jatakas

32. Which of the following was/were not related to Buddha's life?

- 1. Kanthaka
 - 2. Alara Kalama
 - 3. Channa
 - 4. Goshala Maskariputra
- (a) Only 1
(b) Only 4
(c) 1 and 2
(d) 3 and 4

CDS 2013

33. The Fourth Buddhist Council was held in Kashmir under the leadership of

- (a) Bindusara
- (b) Ashoka
- (c) Kunal
- (d) Kanishka

CDS 2014

34. Which of the following statements is/are correct?
CDS 2014

- 1. Early Buddhist literature is generally composed of the canonical text.
 - 2. The Buddhist schools classify their canonical literature as only the Pitakas.
- (a) 1 only
(b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2
(d) Neither 1 nor 2

35. Which of the following statements is/are true? CDS I 2016

- 1. Faxian's 'Gaoseng Faxian zhuan' was the earliest first-hand Chinese account of Buddhist sites and practices in India.
 - 2. Faxian was only 25 years old at the time of writing the text.
 - 3. Faxian's main aim in coming to India was to obtain and take back texts containing monastic rules.
- (a) 1, 2 and 3
(b) 2 only
(c) 1 and 3 only
(d) 3 only

36. Who of the following is a contemporary of Gautama Buddha? NDA 2008 & 2009

- 1. Ashvaghosa
- 2. Nagarjuna
- 3. Parsvanath
- 4. Vardhamana Mahavira

37. Where did Buddha attain Parinirvana? NDA 2009

- 1. Bodh Gaya
- 2. Kushinagara
- 3. Rajgriha
- 4. Vaisali



38. Consider the following statements: 69th BPSC (Pre) 2023

1. Fa-Hien was a Chinese pilgrim who visited India during the reign of Harsha.
2. Hiuen Tsang was a Chinese Buddhist monk who visited India during the reign of Chandragupta II.

Which of the above statements is/are correct?

- (a) Only 1
- (b) Only 2
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) None of the above

39. The painting of 'Bodhisattva Padmapani' is located at:

69th BPSC (Pre) 2023

- (a) Bagh
- (b) Ellora
- (c) Ajanta
- (d) Badami

40. In Indian art, the construction of 'Stupa', 'Chatiya' and 'Vihara' is related to which of the following?

69th BPSC (Pre) 2023

- (a) Ajivika sect
- (b) Vaishnava sect
- (c) Buddhism
- (d) Shaiva sect

41. Consider the following statements about Buddhism.

Odisha PSC (Pre) 2023

- A. It was patronized by the Pala kings.
- B. Buddha was worshipped as a God in Mahayana Buddhism.
- C. Hinayana considers Buddha as an ordinary being who attained Nirvana.
- D. Vajrayana focused on Hindu Practices.

Which of the following are correct?

- (a) B, C and D
- (b) A, B and C
- (c) Only C and D
- (d) All are correct

42. Where do we come across the Madhavapura Mahavihara?

- (a) Ratnagiri **Odisha PSC (Pre) 2023**
- (b) Udayagiri
- (c) Lalitagiri
- (d) Pushpagiri

43. Santarakshita and Dipankara, terms in Medieval India were related to:

JKPSC (Pre) 2023

- (a) Sects of Mahayana Buddhism
- (b) Sects of Digambara in Jainism
- (c) Sects of Lingayats
- (d) Scholars of Buddhism

44. Which of the following statements are true about Buddhism?

TNPSC (Pre) 2022

1. Buddhism denied the authority of Vedas.



2. Buddha's teachings were largely based on Brahmanic ideas of Punarjanma, Karma and Moksha.
3. Buddhism was not practical and ethical.
4. Buddhism accepts God as creator.

- (a) 1, 2, 3 are correct
- (b) 1 and 2 are correct
- (c) Only 2 is correct
- (d) 3 and 4 are correct
- (e) Answer not known

45. The famous physician during Buddha's time was

- (A) Kautilya
- (B) Nachiketa
- (C) Charaka
- (D) Jivaka

WBPSC 2017

46. Where did Gautama Buddha attain Nirvana (enlightenment)?

- (A) Lumbini
- (B) Sarnath
- (C) Kusinagar
- (D) Bodh Gaya

WBPSC 2019

47. Which of the following is one of the sacred book of buddhism?

- (a) torah
- (b) the avesta
- (c) kalpa sutra
- (d) tripitaka

SSC 2020

BUDDHISM PYQ's : (with answers)

1. At which place Gautama Buddha delivered his first sermon?

UPSC 1980 & SSC 2008 & 2018

- (a) Sarnath
- (b) Lumbini
- (c) Bodh Gaya
- (d) Vaishali

Answer: (a) Sarnath

2. Which of the following was the most important characteristic of Kanishka's rule?

UPSC 1980

- (a) Expansion of Buddhism outside India
- (b) Reemergence of Jainism
- (c) Fourth Buddhist Council at Srinagar
- (d) Gandhara School of Art

Answer: (a) Expansion of Buddhism outside India

3. In the Mahayana Buddhism, the Bodhisatva Avalokitesvara was also known as:

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- (b) Manjusri
- (c) Padmapani
- (d) Maitreya

UPSC 1997

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4. Milindapanho is in the form of a dialogue between the king Menander and Buddhist monk

- (a) Nagasena **UPSC 1997**
 (b) Nagarjuna
 (c) Nagabhatta
 (d) Kumarilabhatta

Answer: (a) Nagasena

5. Many of the Greeks, Kushanas and Shakas embraced Buddhism rather than Hinduism because

UPSC 1998

- (a) Buddhism was in the ascendant at that time
 (b) they had renounced the policy of war and violence
 (c) caste-ridden Hinduism did not attract them
 (d) Buddhism provided easier access to Indian society

Answer: (c) caste-ridden Hinduism did not attract them

6. Which of the following pairs are correctly matched? UPSC 1998

1. Lothal : Ancient dockyard
2. Sarnath : First Sermon of Buddha
3. Rajgir : Lion capital of Ashoka
4. Nalanda : Great seat of Buddhist learning

Codes:

- (a) 1, 2, 3 and 4
 (b) 3 and 4

- (c) 1, 2 and 4
 (d) 1 and 2

Answer: (c) 1, 2 and 4 (Note: Rajgir is not associated with the Lion capital of Ashoka; it is Sarnath)

7. According to Buddhism the cause of all sorrows is

- (A) Maya **WBPSC 2016**
 (B) Kama
 (C) Trishna
 (D) Krodh

Answer: (C) Trishna (meaning craving or desire)

8. Who among the following presided over the Buddhist Council held during the reign of Kanishka at Kashmir?

- (a) Parsva **UPSC 2001**
 (b) Nagarjuna
 (c) Sudraka
 (d) Vasumitra

Answer: (d) Vasumitra

9. In ancient Indian Buddhist monasteries, a ceremony called Pavarana used to be held. It was the **UPSC 2002**

- (A) occasion to elect the Sangiparinayaka and two speakers one on Dhamma and the other on Vinaya
 (B) confession by monks of their offences committed during their



stay in the monasteries during the rainy season
(C) ceremony of initiation of new person into the Buddhist Sangha in which the head is shaved and when yellow robes are offered
(D) gathering of Buddhist monks on the next day to the full-moon day of Ashadha when they take up a fixed abode for the next four months of the rainy Season

Answer: (B) confession by monks of their offences committed during their stay in the monasteries during the rainy season

10. Consider the following statements:

UPSC 2004

1. The Chinese pilgrim Fa-Hien attended the fourth Great Buddhist Council held by Kanishka.
 2. The Chinese pilgrim Huen-Tsang met Harsha and found him to be antagonistic to Buddhism.
- (a) 1 only
(b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2
(d) Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (d) Neither 1 nor 2 (Fa-Hien did not attend Kanishka's council; Huen-Tsang found Harsha supportive of Buddhism)

11. Why did Buddhism start declining in India in the early medieval times?

UPSC 2010

1. Buddha was by that time considered as one of the incarnations of Vishnu and thus became a part of Vaishnavism.
2. Invading tribes from Central Asia till the time of last Gupta king adopted Hinduism and persecuted Buddhists.
3. Kings of Gupta dynasty were strongly opposed to Buddhism.

- (a) 1 only
(b) 1 and 3 only
(c) 2 and 3 only
(d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (a) 1 only (Only statement 1 is correct; statements 2 and 3 are historically inaccurate)

12. Lord Buddha's image is sometimes shown with the hand gesture called 'Bhumisparsha Mudra'. It symbolizes **UPSC 2012**

- (a) Buddha's calling of the Earth to watch over Mara and to prevent Mara from disturbing his meditation
(b) Buddha's calling of the Earth to witness his purity and chastity despite the temptations of Mara
(c) Buddha's reminder to his followers that they all arise from the Earth and finally dissolve into the Earth, and thus this life is transitory
(d) Both the statements (a) and (b) are correct in this context

Answer: (b) Buddha's calling of the Earth to witness his purity and



chastity despite the temptations of Mara

13. Which one of the following describes best the concept of Nirvana in Buddhism? UPSC 2013

- (a) The extinction of the flame of desire
- (b) The complete annihilation of self
- (c) A state of bliss and rest
- (d) A mental stage beyond all comprehension.

Answer: (a) The extinction of the flame of desire

14. The 'Four Noble Truths' propounded by Buddha are centred upon GPSC 2017

- 1. Suffering and its extinction
- 2. Right Action
- 3. Ultimate reality
- 4. Salvation

Answer: 1. Suffering and its extinction (The Four Noble Truths are about suffering, its cause, its cessation, and the path to its cessation)

15. With reference to Buddhist history, tradition & culture in India, consider the following pairs:

- 1. Tabo monastery and temple complex : Spiti Valley
- 2. Lhotsava Lhakhang temple, Nako : Zaskar Valley

3. Alehi temple complex : Ladakh

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

UPSC 2014

Answer: (c) 1 and 3 only (Nako is in Himachal Pradesh, not Zaskar Valley)

16. Which of the following Kingdoms were associated with the life of the Buddha?

1. Avanti

UPSC 2014

2. Gandhara

3. Kosala

4. Magadha

- (a) 1, 2 and 3
- (b) 2 and 4
- (c) 3 and 4 only
- (d) 1, 3 and 4

Answer: (c) 3 and 4 only (Kosala and Magadha were directly associated; Avanti and Gandhara were not directly related to Buddha's life)

17. With reference to the religious history of India, consider the following statements:

1. Sautrantika and Sanmitiya were the sects of Jainism.

2. Sarvastivadin held that the constituents of phenomena were not wholly momentary, but existed forever in a latent form.



- (a) 1 only **UPSC 2017**
 (b) 2 only
 (c) Both 1 and 2
 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (b) 2 only (Sautrantika and Sanmitiya were Buddhist sects, not Jain)

18. With reference to Indian history, who among the following is a future Buddha, yet to come to save the world?

- (a) Avalokiteshvara **UPSC 2018**
 (b) Lokeshvara
 (c) Maitreya
 (d) Padmapani

Answer: (c) Maitreya

19. Consider the following:

1. Deification of the Buddha
2. Treading the Path of Bodhisattvas
3. Image worship and rituals

Which of the above is/are the feature/features of Mahayana Buddhism?

- (a) 1 only **UPSC 2019**
 (b) 1 and 2 only
 (c) 2 and 3 only
 (d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) 1, 2 and 3 (All are features of Mahayana Buddhism)

20. With reference to the religious history of India, consider the following statements: UPSC 2020

1. Sthaviravadins belong to Mahayana Buddhism.
 2. Lokottaravadin sect was an offshoot of Mahasanghika sect of Buddhism.
 3. The deification of Buddha by Mahasanghikas fostered Mahayana Buddhism.
- (a) 1 and 2 only
 (b) 2 and 3 only
 (c) 3 only
 (d) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b) 2 and 3 only (Sthaviravadins are Hinayana, not Mahayana)

21. With reference to Indian history, consider the following pairs: UPSC 2022

1. Aryadeva - Jaina scholar
2. Dignaga - Buddhist scholar
3. Nathamuni - Vaishnava scholar

How many pairs given above are correctly matched?

- (a) None of the pairs
 (b) Only one pair
 (c) Only two pairs
 (d) All three pairs

Answer: (c) Only two pairs (Aryadeva was a Buddhist scholar, not Jaina; Dignaga was Buddhist; Nathamuni was Vaishnava)



22. With reference to ancient India, consider the following statements:

UPSC CSE 2023

1. The concept of Stupa is Buddhist in origin.
2. Stupa was generally a repository of relics.
3. Stupa was a votive and commemorative structure in Buddhist tradition.

How many of the statements given above are correct?

- (a) Only one
- (b) Only two
- (c) All three
- (d) None

Answer: (b) Only two (Statements 2 and 3 are correct; statement 1 is incorrect as stupa predates Buddhism)

23. Sanghabhuti, an Indian Buddhist monk, who travelled to China at the end of the fourth century AD, was the author of a commentary on : **UPSC CSE 2024**

- (a) Prajnaparamita Sutra
- (b) Visuddhimanga
- (c) Sarvastivada Vinaya
- (d) Lolitavistara

Answer: (c) Sarvastivada Vinaya

24. With reference to ancient India, Gautama Buddha was generally known by which of the following epithets?

1. Nayaputta **UPSC CSE**
2. Shakyamuni
3. Tathagata

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1, 2 and 3
- (d) None of the above are epithets of Gautama Buddha

Answer: (b) 2 and 3

only (Nayaputta is an epithet for Mahavira, not Buddha)

25. Fa-hien (Faxian), the Chinese pilgrim, travelled to India during the reign of

- (a) Samudragupta **UPSC CSE 2025**
- (b) Chandragupta II
- (c) Kumaragupta I
- (d) Skandagupta

Answer: (b) Chandragupta II

26. The important contribution of Jainism to Indian Philosophy is the doctrine of

1. Rebirth **GPSC 2017**
2. Karma
3. Existence of Individual souls



4.Syadvada

Answer: 4. Syadvada (the theory of conditional predication)

27. Which one of the following statements about Buddhist Stupas in India is not correct? CDS 1 2018

- (a) Ashoka played an important role in popularizing the Stupa cult.
- (b) They were repositories of relics of Buddha and other monks.
- (c) They were located in rural areas.
- (d) They were located close to trade routes.

Answer: (c) They were located in rural areas (Many stupas were located near urban centers or trade routes, not exclusively rural)

28. In which predominantly Buddhist nation of Asia did Pope Francis in November 2017 preach a message of forgiveness to a huge crowd?

- (a) Bhutan **SSC 2018**
- (b) Myanmar
- (c) Thailand
- (d) Mongolia

Answer: (b) Myanmar

29. The Buddha delivered his first sermon, known as 'Turning of the wheel of law' at

- (a) Sanchi **CDS 2008**
- (b) Sarnath
- (c) Sravasti
- (d) Bodh Gaya

Answer: (b) Sarnath

30. In Buddhism, what does Patimokkha stand for? CDS 2008

- (a) A description of Mahayana Buddhism
- (b) A description of Hinayana Buddhism
- (c) The rules of the Sangha
- (d) The questions of king Menander

Answer: (c) The rules of the Sangha

31. The earliest Buddhist literature which deal with the stories of the various birth of Buddha are

- (a) Vinaya pitakas **CDS 2011**
- (b) Sutta pitakas
- (c) Abhidamma pitakas
- (d) Jatakas

Answer: (d) Jatakas

32. Which of the following was/were not related to Buddha's life?

- 1.Kanthaka **CDS 2013**
- 2.Alara Kalama
- 3.Channa
- 4.Goshala Maskariputra
- (a) Only 1
- (b) Only 4
- (c) 1 and 2
- (d) 3 and 4

Answer: (b) Only 4 (Goshala Maskariputra was a contemporary of Mahavira, not Buddha)



33. The Fourth Buddhist Council was held in Kashmir under the leadership of

- (a) Bindusara
(b) Ashoka
(c) Kunal
(d) Kanishka

CDS 2014**Answer: (d) Kanishka****34. Which of the following statements is/are correct?
CDS 2014**

1. Early Buddhist literature is generally composed of the canonical text.
2. The Buddhist schools classify their canonical literature as only the Pitakas.
- (a) 1 only
(b) 2 only
(c) Both 1 and 2
(d) Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (a) 1 only (Statement 2 is incorrect as canonical literature includes more than just Pitakas, e.g., Jatakas)

35. Which of the following statements is/are true? CDS I 2016

1. Faxian's 'Gaoseng Faxian zhuan' was the earliest first-hand Chinese account of Buddhist sites and practices in India.
2. Faxian was only 25 years old at the time of writing the text.

3. Faxian's main aim in coming to India was to obtain and take back texts containing monastic rules.

- (a) 1, 2 and 3
(b) 2 only
(c) 1 and 3 only
(d) 3 only

Answer: (c) 1 and 3 only (Faxian was not 25 years old when he wrote the account)

36. Who of the following is a contemporary of Gautama Buddha? NDA 2008 & 2009

1. Ashvaghosa
2. Nagarjuna
3. Parsvanath
4. Vardhamana Mahavira

Answer: 4. Vardhamana Mahavira (Only Mahavira was a contemporary; others came later)

37. Where did Buddha attain Parinirvana? NDA 2009

1. Bodh Gaya
2. Kushinagara
3. Rajgriha
4. Vaisali

Answer: 2. Kushinagara



38. Consider the following statements: 69th BPSC (Pre) 2023

1. Fa-Hien was a Chinese pilgrim who visited India during the reign of Harsha.
2. Hiuen Tsang was a Chinese Buddhist monk who visited India during the reign of Chandragupta II.

Which of the above statements is/are correct?

- (a) Only 1
- (b) Only 2
- (c) Both 1 and 2
- (d) None of the above

Answer: (d) None of the above (Fa-Hien visited during Chandragupta II; Hiuen Tsang during Harsha)

39. The painting of 'Bodhisattva Padmapani' is located at: 69th BPSC (Pre) 2023

- (a) Bagh
- (b) Ellora
- (c) Ajanta
- (d) Badami

Answer: (c) Ajanta

40. In Indian art, the construction of 'Stupa', 'Chatiya' and 'Vihara' is related to which of the following?

69th BPSC (Pre) 2023

- (a) Ajivika sect
- (b) Vaishnava sect
- (c) Buddhism

(d) Shaiva sect

Answer: (c) Buddhism

41. Consider the following statements about Buddhism.

Odisha PSC (Pre) 2023

- A. It was patronized by the Pala kings.
- B. Buddha was worshipped as a God in Mahayana Buddhism.
- C. Hinayana considers Buddha as an ordinary being who attained Nirvana.
- D. Vajrayana focused on Hindu Practices.

Which of the following are correct?

- (a) B, C and D
- (b) A, B and C
- (c) Only C and D
- (d) All are correct

Answer: (d) All are correct

42. Where do we come across the Madhavapura Mahavihara?

- (a) Ratnagiri **Odisha PSC (Pre) 2023**
- (b) Udayagiri
- (c) Lalitagiri
- (d) Pushpagiri

Answer: (b) Udayagiri

43. Santarakshita and Dipankara, terms in Medieval India were related to: JKPSC (Pre) 2023

- (a) Sects of Mahayana Buddhism
- (b) Sects of Digambara in Jainism
- (c) Sects of Lingayats
- (d) Scholars of Buddhism

Answer: (d) Scholars of Buddhism



44. Which of the following statements are true about Buddhism? **TNPSC (Pre) 2022**

1. Buddhism denied the authority of Vedas.
 2. Buddha's teachings were largely based on Brahmanic ideas of Punarjanma, Karma and Moksha.
 3. Buddhism was not practical and ethical.
 4. Buddhism accepts God as creator.
- (a) 1, 2, 3 are correct
(b) 1 and 2 are correct
(c) Only 2 is correct
(d) 3 and 4 are correct
(e) Answer not known

Answer: (b) 1 and 2 are correct

45. The famous physician during Buddha's time was

- (A) Kautilya **WBPSC 2017**
(B) Nachiketa
(C) Charaka
(D) Jivaka

Answer: (D) Jivaka

46. Where did Gautama Buddha attain Nirvana (enlightenment)?

- (A) Lumbini **WBPSC 2019**
(B) Sarnath
(C) Kusinagar
(D) Bodh Gaya

Answer: (D) Bodh Gaya

47. Which of the following is one of the sacred book of buddhism?

- (a) torah **SSC 2020**
(b) the avesta
(c) kalpa sutra
(d) tripitaka

Answer: (d) tripitaka

